

Southcentral Regional Hearing for Congressional Redistricting State Government Committee

Testimony of L. Michael Ross, President
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October 13, 2021

I extend my thanks to Chairman Grove, Representatives Kauffman and Schemel and all members of the State Government Committee for inviting me to testify today. As a matter of introduction, I am Mike Ross, President of the Franklin County Area Development Corporation (FCADC), a position I have had since the FCADC start-up in 1986. The FCADC is a Certified Economic Development Organization (CEDO) whose mission is to formulate, implement and promote economic strategies for Franklin County that emphasize planned growth and family sustaining employment. Our efforts are concentrated on the retention and expansion of existing companies, the selective attraction of new industries, and the start-up of new businesses. Over the last 35 years we have supported more than 800 development projects that have led to more than \$2 Billion of capital investments and the creation/retention of more than 50,000 jobs.

Legislative districting at both the federal and state levels have profound consequences for local governments (both county and municipal) and service providers, especially in the establishment of meaningful relationships with elected representatives. Those relationships are critical to efforts for accessing limited resources in support of everything from agriculture-to-education-to infrastructure-to human services. For that reason, I am strongly recommending that Franklin County remain in the 13th congressional district currently represented by Dr. John Joyce.

Some may be surprised by my recommendation given Franklin County's location and economy. There is no county more south-centrally located than Franklin and none more peripheral to the political alignments of what is perceived to be "south-central Pennsylvania." The perception of the region, which has been widely created by the media, is a Harrisburg-York-Lancaster triangle which in addition to Dauphin, York and Lancaster counties includes Cumberland, Lebanon, Perry, and Adams counties. News coverage typically cuts off at Carlisle unless there is a significant traffic accident on I-81 or one of our local high schools is competing for a state championship. Having had this conversation with elected and bureaucratic policy makers for the last 35-years, little is known about Franklin County.

Traversed by I-81, Franklin County is among the 10 fastest growing counties in Pennsylvania with a population of 155,932 but is still substantially smaller in population and more rural than Cumberland, Dauphin and York counties. Franklin County is one of the leading agricultural counties in the state, especially as it relates to dairy and fruit production. The county is uniquely positioned as part of a four-state regional economy that also includes Washington County, Maryland (Hagerstown); Berkeley County, West Virginia (Martinsburg); and Frederick County, Virginia (Winchester). Our Quad-State tag line is "4 States-4 Counties-40 Miles." As a quad-state region, we share I-81, proximity to Washington, DC, and a labor shed. Economically, Franklin County is as connected to the quad-state region...in many ways more so...than to the other counties in southcentral Pennsylvania. Our quad-state economy is interconnected and expanding significantly, yet, coincidentally, each of the quad-state counties is marginally on the radar of policy makers in their respective states.

Historically, Franklin County has been part of the same congressional district for decades. Formerly part of the 9th congressional district until the 2010 redistricting when it became the 13th district, Franklin

has grown to be the biggest county in the district and with all due respect to the others, the most vibrant economy due to our I-81 location. Our position as the largest and most vibrant county in the district demand that our congressional representative be actively engaged in issues and initiatives impacting us. Since his election in 2018, Congressman Joyce, like his predecessor Bill Shuster, has been actively engaged across the county on projects like Herbruck's Poultry Ranch-a \$100 million ag investment in Mercersburg-to-the expansions of JLG Industries and Martin's Potato Rolls-to support for the Letterkenny Army Depot, WellSpan Health, Shippensburg and Penn State-Mont Alto universities as well as Wilson College.

I mentioned congressional support for Letterkenny. Letterkenny is the only major defense installation in the 13th district and as such has the full attention of our congressman. If Franklin County was redistricted to become part of the current 10th district encompassing southcentral Pennsylvania, it would be one of four installations and would not have the same political or economic importance. Should there be a future BRAC, the Depot could easily be a target for closure or downsizing and if so, it would be difficult for the 10th district representative to make an economic development argument given that it would be one of four in his/her district. As the only installation in the 13th district, a predominately rural district, the economic impact is more easily quantified and impactful. To that point, according to an economic impact analysis commissioned by the Pennsylvania Military Community Enhancement Commission, the Letterkenny Army Depot has a \$1.75 BILLION annual economic impact on Franklin County. Removing that impact would have a devastating effect on Franklin County and have a severe ripple effect on the overall 13th District; however if we were part of the 10th district, the consequences for Franklin County would be the same, however it would have a far less impact on the rest of the 10th District.

In conclusion, being a part of the 13th district, in my opinion, has served Franklin County extremely well and I strongly recommend our continued inclusion.